

I work in, I've already seen many writers and artists lose their income to terrible software replacements, because businesses care about cost-saving, not quality (and the quality of the software will only improve) and assume that consumers won't care either. And the thing is, at the macro level, they're not wrong—consumers can be trained not to care. Meanwhile, other creators whose own careers are safe from technology explain that AI can never reach the quality of human art, or how humans and machines can collaborate to create greater brilliance. Again, not untrue—but it just means that only the privileged can create art, which has often been the case in human history, but also that the promises of new technology to democratise art were lies. This makes AI yet another frightening tool in the hands of the powerful.

Why is AI being used to 'fix' systems that are flawed but working? Why is AI replacing illustrators, not malfunctioning people with power? Why is AI not doing the boring jobs, just cost-cutting the interesting ones? There is no shortage of problems in the world, or crises where better technology could help, or work that is very dangerous, or tedious, or humiliating. Where are the AI solutions for those? AI is an amazing tool only in a world where human systems already fundamentally work, a utopia where humans create art and experience leisure, while machines do the humdrum stuff. Why is that possible only in science fiction?

In fiction terms, right now AI as a concept is promising *Star Trek*. But what techbros are actually trying to build is *Black Mirror*. Currently, they're actually building *Khosla ka Ghosla*, which will change. But nothing about AI in the near future looks good—mostly just tech-oligarchs offering shiny new toys that will make creaking, flawed systems and the people that work in them irrelevant, and then it will turn out the toys don't work either. This isn't just pessimism, or the fear of change, but the growing certainty that the few people running the world will really enjoy a beautiful, organised planet without the inconvenience of billions of other humans swarming around it. When we look around the planet now, we can see only too clearly how cheap human life is, and how most prosperous countries are more concerned with building walls and grabbing resources than even pretending that international law or human rights exist. It's not going to get easier, as climate change makes things worse and immigration and food crises make humanity even more feral. Not the time to be excited by tech that makes more people irrelevant. ■